

Appendix E — Sources

Every factual claim in this book traces to a source. This appendix is the map of those sources, arranged so you can *use* them: grouped by what you would go to them for, with a note on what each one settles.

It is not the full research ledger. The full ledger — 216 sources with the exact sentence each one verified — lives in `research/sources-ledger.md`. What follows is the working set: the pages worth your time while you prepare, plus the two files you must never open, and the method for checking any source yourself.

The hierarchy, in plain words

There are only four organisations that can tell you what IELTS is: **ielts.org** (the partnership's own site), the **British Council**, **IDP Education**, and **Cambridge University Press & Assessment**. Between them they write the test, train the examiners, publish the band descriptors and decide the rules. When one of them says something about format, timing, scoring or policy, that is not an opinion — it is the rule. Everything on those four domains is what this book calls **Tier 1**.

Below that sit the **strategy sources** — IELTS Liz, IELTS Simon, E2, IELTS Advantage, Magoosh, and the academic literature on language testing. Several are written by former examiners and they are genuinely good. But they are **Tier 2**, and the distinction is not snobbery, it is about what a source can be wrong about. A prep blog can teach you a superb method for attacking Matching Headings; it cannot tell you what the band-7 descriptor says, because it does not write the band-7 descriptor. Use Tier 2 for **technique**. Never for **rules**.

The practical version of that rule: **if a Tier 2 source contradicts a Tier 1 source, the Tier 2 source is wrong**. This is not hypothetical. Building this book turned up a widely repeated blog claim that a Task 1 answer with no overview "scores below a 5" — the official 2023 descriptors explicitly describe a band-5 script that has no overview. It turned up a "73% of test-takers" collocation statistic that traces to nothing at all. It turned up two different superseded band-descriptor PDFs outranking the current ones in search results. Every one of those would have cost you real marks if you had trusted it.

Anything that is neither official nor an established strategy expert is **Tier 3**: useful for finding out what questions people ask, worthless as evidence. Nothing in this book rests on a Tier 3 source.

Official format and rules

The pages that define what happens on the day. Read these once properly, early. Everything else is commentary on them.

Source	Use it for
<code>ielts.org/take-a-test/test-types/ielts-academic-test</code>	Bookmark. The hub: all four papers, durations, the 2h45 total
<code>.../ielts-academic-format-listening</code>	Listening: ~30 min, 4 parts, 40 questions, the 10-minute transfer (paper only)
<code>.../ielts-academic-format-reading</code>	Reading: 60 minutes including transfer — there is no extra time. 2,150–2,750 words, 11 question types, "each correct answer receives 1 mark" and no deduction clause
<code>.../ielts-academic-format-writing</code>	Bookmark. 150/250 word minimums, 20/40 minute split, and the sentence the whole Writing calculation depends on: "Task 2 contributes twice as much as Task 1"

Source	Use it for
.../ielts-academic-format-speaking	Speaking: 11–14 minutes, the three parts and their lengths
takeielts.britishcouncil.org/take-ielts/prepare/test-format	Paper order and the same-day rule; Speaking up to 7 days either side
takeielts.britishcouncil.org/frequently-asked-questions	Bookmark. The single densest policy page: TRF validity, results turnaround by mode, ID rules, stationery rules, "marks are not deducted for making corrections"
cambridgeenglish.org/images/269898-ielts-academic-faqs.pdf	Cambridge's own FAQ. "There is no direct penalty for writing fewer than 150 words", the over-word-limit rule, the memorised-essay warning
ielts.org/take-a-test/preparation-resources/on-test-day	Test-day rules: ID, belongings, no watches, water in a clear bottle, no breaks
takeielts.britishcouncil.org/take-ielts/test-day-advice	Photograph, finger scan, black pen supplied, no personal stationery
ielts.idp.com/about/test-day	IDP's version, and the only source describing what the <i>computer</i> room gives you (pens, paper, login sheet)
ielts.org/news-and-insights/updates-to-ielts-test-delivery	Bookmark if you are testing in 2026. Paper discontinued from mid-2026; "Writing on Paper" introduced; timelines vary by market
takeielts.britishcouncil.org/take-ielts/prepare/free-ielts-english-practice-tests/ielts-on-computer/how-it-works	Bookmark. Seven short official videos showing the computer interface — Listening, Reading, Writing, highlighting, note-taking, the Help button. Free, and the highest-value hour you can spend if you are testing on computer
.../ielts-on-computer/about/highlighting-text	Exactly how the highlighter works, and confirmation that examiners never see it
.../ielts-on-computer/about/making-notes	The note-taking tool (video only — no transcript published)
ielts.idp.com/prepare/article-how-computer-delivered-ielts-works	Bookmark. The richest single description of the computer test: word counter position, flashing timer, review/flag button, no transfer time in Listening, only 2 minutes to check
ielts.org/take-a-test/test-types/ielts-academic-test/ielts-online	Read before you consider IELTS Online: "not currently accepted for immigration purposes"
ielts.org/take-a-test/booking-your-test/one-skill-retake	One Skill Retake: computer-delivered only, within 60 days, one retake per test
ielts.idp.com/results/request-remark	Enquiry on Results: the 6-week deadline, fee refunded if a band changes

Band descriptors and assessment criteria

These are the four files that decide your score. Everything else in this book is an argument about how to satisfy them. Download all four; check the edition date on each before you read a word of it (see *Do not cite*, below).

File	What it is
ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-writing-band-descriptors.pdf	The single most important document you will read. 9 pages. Task 1 grid pp.3–5, Task 2 grid pp.7–9. Current edition: created 3 May 2023
ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-speaking-band-descriptors.pdf	Speaking grid, four criteria. Current edition: created 16 September 2025 — a newer revision than the Writing file, which catches people out

File	What it is
ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-writing-key-assessment-criteria.pdf	The companion prose. Defines each criterion — including the fact that spelling and word formation are scored under Lexical Resource, not Grammar
ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-speaking-key-assessment-criteria.pdf	The same for Speaking, including the appropriacy dimension of Lexical Resource

Two things in the descriptor header do most of the work, and most candidates never read them: *a script must fully fit the positive features of a band to be rated there*, and *bolded text marks negative features that will limit a rating*. If you only half-fit band 7, you are a 6.

Supporting:

- ielts.org/organisations/ielts-for-organisations/understanding-ielts-scoring — where the current PDFs actually live, plus confirmation that the four criteria are equally weighted and Task 2 carries more weight.
- ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-guide-for-teachers.pdf — written for teachers, which is why it explains the criteria more plainly than anything aimed at candidates.
- ielts.idp.com/prepare/article-understanding-the-ielts-speaking-band-descriptors — IDP's plain-English walk-through of the Speaking grid.

Official practice material and sample tests

Original, official, free. Use these before anything you pay for.

Source	Use it for
takeielts.britishcouncil.org/take-ielts/prepare/free-ielts-english-practice-tests	Bookmark. The free British Council inventory: full Listening tests, Academic Reading and Writing practice, Speaking guidance, computer familiarisation
takeielts.britishcouncil.org/take-ielts/prepare/ielts-ready	Bookmark. Free tier gives a 50-minute mini mock with AI feedback and two full mocks. Premium — 40 full practice tests — is free when you book with the British Council , so book first, then use it

Source	Use it for
ielts.org/cdn/Sample-tests/ielts-academic-writing-sample-tasks-2023.pdf	The best free item in existence for Writing. Real scripts at bands 5 to 8.5 with the examiner's own comments explaining exactly what capped each one
ielts.org/cdn/computer-delivered-sample-tests-academic-writing/...example-responses...pdf	The same, for computer-delivered format
ielts.org/cdn/Sample-tests/ielts-academic-reading-sample-tasks-2023.pdf	Official Reading tasks with answer keys
ielts.org/cdn/ielts-sample-tests/ielts-listening-sample-tasks-2023.pdf	Official Listening tasks
ielts.org/cdn/ielts-sample-tests/ielts-speaking-sample-tasks-2023.pdf	Official Part 2 cue cards and Part 3 question sets
cambridgeenglish.org/images/ielts-academic-reading-task-type-*.pdf	A separate PDF per Reading question type (multiple choice, T/F/NG and Y/N/NG, matching information, matching headings, matching features, matching sentence endings, summary and table completion, diagram labelling, short answer), each with worked practice. The most systematic free Reading resource anywhere
takeielts.britishcouncil.org/sites/default/files/reading_tfng_.pdf and siblings (reading_matching_headings_ , reading_matching_features_ , reading_completion_questions_)	British Council type-specific Reading worksheets

Source	Use it for
takeielts.britishcouncil.org/sites/default/files/speaking_part_3_overview_and_practice.pdf	Official Part 3 practice
ielts.org/take-a-test/preparation-resources/writing-test-resources	Free official videos of Writing being scored
cambridge.org/cambridgeenglish/catalog/.../ielts-21-practice-tests	<i>IELTS 21</i> (July 2026) — the current Cambridge volume. Four authentic papers. This is what you buy when the free material runs out

Scoring and band conversion

How raw marks become bands — and the one detail almost every prep site gets wrong.

Source	Use it for
ielts.org/for-test-takers/how-ielts-is-scored	The 9-band scale, the overall-band rounding rule (.25 rounds up, .75 rounds up), and the four official anchor points : Listening 16/23/30/35, Academic Reading 15/23/30/35
ielts.org/take-a-test/your-results/ielts-scoring-in-detail	The same anchors with three worked rounding examples, and the caveat that thresholds vary slightly by test version
ielts.idp.com/turkey/results/scores/reading/en-gb	The full Academic Reading table, half bands included — 40–39=9, 38–37=8.5, 36–35=8, 34–33=7.5, 32–30=7, 29–27=6.5, 26–23=6, 22–19=5.5, 18–15=5
ielts.idp.com/thailand/results/scores/listening	The full Listening table, half bands included — 39–40=9, 37–38=8.5, 35–36=8, 32–34=7.5, 30–31=7, 26–29=6.5, 23–25=6, 18–22=5.5, 16–17=5

A trap worth knowing about. IDP publishes different content on different country sites. The Listening table above is on the **Thailand** page. The canonical ielts.idp.com/results/scores/listening loads perfectly and gives only one worked example — no table. The Turkey page, which *does* carry the Reading table, does *not* carry the Listening one. If you go looking for these figures and land on the wrong market's page, you will conclude no official half-band table exists. It does. Both tables carry the same official caveat: these are average thresholds, and "actual marks may vary slightly between tests".

For Writing, IELTS publishes the 1:2 weighting of Task 1 to Task 2 but **not** the arithmetic. $(\text{Task 1} + 2 \times \text{Task 2}) \div 3$ is a well-grounded estimate, and this book labels it as one. Do not present the result as the number IELTS would compute.

Tunisia-specific

Source	Use it for
ielts.org/test-centres/british-council-tunis	Bookmark. The live centre listing: address, current fees in TND, and the booking links — which are all computer-delivered
britishcouncil.tn/en/exam/ielts/dates-fees-locations	Five test locations: Tunis, Bizerte, Sousse, Sfax, Gabes. Computer-delivered and IELTS Online
britishcouncil.tn/fr/examen/ielts/reserver-examen	ID and payment rules in French: same document for booking and test day; payment in dinar only, no hard currency, no cash
britishcouncil.tn/en/exam/ielts/one-skill-retake	One Skill Retake in Tunisia — the global rules are stated, but no Tunisian centre is named , so confirm by phone

The known conflict: the French booking page still advertises "IELTS Academic (papier ou ordinateur)" while the English pages and the live ielts.org listing show computer only. That is almost certainly stale copy predating the mid-2026 paper withdrawal. Settle it with a phone call to the centre, not from the website — and train on a keyboard either way.

Research and evidence

Where this book's claims about *your specific error patterns* come from.

- ielts.org/cdn/Research/investigating-development-of-grammatical-range-and-accuracy-at-different-proficiency-levels-roothoof-et-al-2019.pdf — Roothoof, Breeze et al., *IELTS Research Reports* 2019/1. **Bookmark.** The most useful single research artefact for a band-6-to-7 candidate: it measures which grammatical errors actually discriminate between bands. Articles fall from an 18.4% error rate at band 6 to 7.4% at band 7 — the largest discontinuity in the study. Third-person -s omission collapses from 70.6% to 7.6%. And overuse errors against the plural (*peoples, informations*) are the one category that does **not** resolve as proficiency rises.
- ielts.org/researchers/our-research/test-statistics and the accompanying test-taker performance spreadsheet — mean bands by first language, so you can see where Arabic and French L1 candidates actually lose marks.
- files.eric.ed.gov (TESL-EJ and ELT journal papers), onlinelibrary.wiley.com (*TESOL Quarterly, Language Learning*) — the second-language acquisition literature behind the L1-interference chapter.
- owl.purdue.edu/.../runonsentences.html, learnenglish.britishcouncil.org/grammar/.../uncount-nouns, eapfoundation.com/vocab/academic/awllists/ — grammar and academic-vocabulary reference. The last one is the Academic Word List, sublist by sublist.

Strategy sources (Tier 2)

Technique only. None of these decides a rule; several teach method better than the official pages do.

Source	Strongest for
IELTS Liz (ieltsliz.com)	The broadest coverage, ex-examiner. Best on Listening prediction, Reading question types, computer-delivered pros and cons, and how words are counted
IELTS Simon (ielts-simon.study , ielts-simon.com)	Ruthless data selection in Task 1 — mark the biggest number in each row and column, ignore the middle. Note: many of the old ielts-simon.com article URLs now 404; the .study site is the live one
IELTS Advantage (ieltsadvantage.com)	Task 1 overview structure and Reading time management

Source	Strongest for
E2 (e2language.com)	Listening distractor types – the best single treatment of how wrong answers are built
Magoosh (magoosh.com/ielts/)	Clear, well-organised summaries; good for a second opinion on word count and band estimation

Two further prep blogs – myieltsclassroom.com and ieltsfocus.com – are cited once or twice each for practitioner technique. They are outside the shortlist above, so treat them as corroboration only.

Do not cite

⚠️ Two superseded PDFs outrank the current ones in search results

Both of these load, both look official, both are **years out of date**, and both are what you will find if you simply search for "IELTS band descriptors". Two different researchers on this project walked into them independently.

File	Edition	How to recognise it
<code>assets.ctfassets.net/.../writingbanddescriptorstask1and2.pdf</code>	Writing, last modified 13 June 2013	2 pages, no Title, no Author, Creator Nitro Pro 8. Its band-7 Academic Task Achievement line reads <i>"presents a clear overview of main trends, differences or stages"</i> — wording the 2023 edition does not use. The current file is 9 pages
<code>assets.cambridgeenglish.org/webinars/ielts-speaking-band-descriptors.pdf</code>	Speaking, created 29 September 2008, modified 21 May 2013	1 page, Title blank, Author borour, Creator Acrobat PDFMaker 7.0.7 for Word. Its band-6 Pronunciation cell omits chunking, stress-timing and speech rate entirely; its band-7 Grammar cell omits the simple-and-complex-sentences clause. The current file is 4 pages

The cost of using one is not academic. The 2008 Speaking file's band-7 Fluency wording is materially different from the 2025 edition, and studying the wrong one means optimising for a target that no longer exists.

Always check the edition date before you trust a descriptor PDF. Three ways, cheapest first:

1. **Count the pages.** Current Writing = 9. Current Speaking = 4. A 1- or 2-page "band descriptors" file is old.
2. **Open Document Properties** in any PDF reader and read Title, Author and Created. The current files say Author IELTS and carry a real title.
3. **Read the metadata directly**, which is what this project did:

```
python import pdfplumber with pdfplumber.open("descriptors.pdf") as pdf: print(pdf.metadata) # Title, Author, Creator, CreationDate, ModDate print(len(pdf.pages))
```

Real output from the current Writing file: Title: IELTS Writing Band Descriptors, Author: IELTS, CreationDate: D:20230503..., 9 pages. Real output from the 2013 file: no Title, no Author, Creator: Nitro Pro 8, ModDate: D:20130613..., 2 pages. The difference takes ten seconds to see.

Download the current descriptors only from ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/. The British Council mirror at takeielts.britishcouncil.org/sites/default/files/ielts_writing_band_descriptors.pdf is the same May 2023 edition and is safe; the two files above are not.

How to check a source yourself

Four habits. They are the whole method, and they generalise well beyond IELTS.

1. Check the PDF's edition date before you read it. Page count, then Document Properties, then metadata. A PDF has no expiry notice and no banner telling you it has been replaced — the date is the only signal, and search engines rank by popularity, not currency.

2. Prefer the official domain, and check you are on it. `ielts.org`, `takeielts.britishcouncil.org`, `ielts.idp.com`, `cambridgeenglish.org`. Note the near-misses: `idp.com` is the parent company's corporate blog, not the test site; `cambridge.org/elt/blog` is a publisher's marketing blog, not the exam board. Both are fine reading and neither is authoritative.

3. A 403 is not proof a page is gone. Several official sites — the British Council estate especially, and `britishcouncil.tn` — sit behind bot protection that rejects automated fetchers with a 403 or a broken connection while serving browsers normally. During this project, the British Council's own copy of the Writing band descriptors was recorded as "could not be retrieved" for exactly this reason; re-tested with a different tool, it loaded on the first attempt and turned out to be the correct current edition. **Open the URL in a browser before you conclude anything is dead.** A genuine 404 says so plainly; bot protection does not.

4. Check whether you are on a market variant. IDP publishes country-specific sites — `/thailand/`, `/turkey/`, `/canada/`, `/philippines/` — and their content is *not* identical. The Listening band-conversion table exists on the Thailand page and not on the canonical one. The British Council does the same across national sites, and `britishcouncil.tn` currently contradicts the global pages on whether paper tests are still bookable. When a figure matters, check a second market's page before deciding the figure does not exist — and when two official pages disagree, the more specific and more recently updated one usually wins, with policy pages outranking blog posts.

Verification statement

All sources in this appendix were fetched and verified on 31 July 2026. Every quotation attributed to an official source was read on the live page or extracted from the live PDF on that date, not carried over from memory or from a secondary site. Where a page could not be retrieved, or where the content is delivered as video with no published transcript, the ledger says so rather than implying verification.

Re-check format, fees and policy before your test date. IELTS changes: the paper test is being withdrawn from mid-2026 on a timetable that varies by market, the Speaking descriptors were revised in 2025 while the Writing descriptors date from 2023, and Tunisian fees and centre locations are set locally. Nothing in this book is a substitute for the official page on the morning you book. Re-read three things before you sit the test: the format pages for your delivery mode, the current band descriptors, and your test centre's own page.